

# CHAPTER ONE: "THE LAST PAGE ISN'T IN THE SCRIPT"

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March – May 2007

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## **TIMELINE: AGES ON DAY ONE (MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007)**

| Person            | Born          | Age                      |
|-------------------|---------------|--------------------------|
| Kevin Feige       | June 2, 1973  | 33                       |
| Avi Arad          | Aug 1, 1948   | 58                       |
| Jon Favreau       | Oct 19, 1966  | 40                       |
| Robert Downey Jr. | Apr 4, 1965   | 41 (42 on Apr 4)         |
| Gwyneth Paltrow   | Sept 27, 1972 | 34                       |
| Terrence Howard   | Mar 11, 1969  | 38 (turned 38 yesterday) |
| Jeff Bridges      | Dec 4, 1949   | 57                       |
| Samuel L. Jackson | Dec 21, 1948  | 58                       |
| Stan Lee          | Dec 28, 1922  | 84                       |

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## HOLLYWOOD TRADES

**VARIETY** | *Monday, March 12, 2007*

### **MARVEL UPS FEIGE TO PRODUCTION PREZ**

*Longtime Arad lieutenant takes the reins as indie studio's first self-financed pic, 'Iron Man,' begins lensing today.*

**THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER** | *March 12, 2007*

### **'IRON MAN' ROLLS: Downey suits up as Marvel bets \$140M on itself**

*Analysts question whether a comic company can survive without a studio's safety net. "If 'Iron Man' misses, Marvel's collateral is Captain America," said one financier. "Imagine explaining that to shareholders."*

**DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY (Nikki Finke)** | *March 12, 2007, 9:14 PM PT*

### **TOLDJA: Marvel's Beverly Hills skeleton crew is making a play**

*Sources say Maisel's Merrill Lynch money comes with 10 characters attached. Why is a company making ONE movie locking actors into NINE-picture deals? Somebody over the Mercedes dealership is thinking big. Or crazy.*

## THE FANS

**SUPERHEROHYPE.COM FORUMS › *Iron Man (2008)* › "PRINCIPAL PHOTOGRAPHY BEGINS — DISCUSSION THREAD"**

*Page 1 of 47*

**ShellHead\_1963** — *Mar 12 2007, 10:02 AM*

IT'S HAPPENING. Downey is Tony. I've said it since September. The man IS a recovering genius disaster. Casting of the decade.

**XxWolverineXx** — *Mar 12 2007, 10:09 AM*

lol ok. B-list hero, a guy nobody's hired since Ally McBeal, and a studio that's never made a movie. See you at the \$90M opening. Domestic TOTAL.

**Rhodey4WarMachine** — *Mar 12 2007, 10:31 AM*

Terrence Howard as Rhodey. Pay attention to him. Mark my words, we see the silver suit by the sequel.

**ExcelsiorFaithful** — *Mar 12 2007, 11:47 AM*

Only thing I care about: IS IT COMIC ACCURATE? Stane better BE Iron Monger. Don't give me some made-up villain.

**Mjolnir\_Worthy** — *Mar 12 2007, 12:20 PM*

Weird question. Marvel ALSO has Hulk shooting this summer with Norton. Two movies, same year, same studio. Anyone else think they're connected?

**XxWolverineXx** — *Mar 12 2007, 12:22 PM*

@Mjolnir\_Worthy no. That's not how movies work. Different directors, different distributors. Calm down.

**TWITTER** (*SXSW Interactive, Austin, TX. Twitter's usage explodes this week*)

**@geekdad\_atx** — *4:51 PM Mar 12th, 2007*

at SXSW, everyone twittering about twitter. meanwhile Iron Man started filming today and nobody here cares. wrong room.

## SCENE 1

EXT. OWENS VALLEY / LONE PINE, CALIFORNIA — "AFGHANISTAN" CAVE SET — DAY  
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 — 6:47 AM PT

Wind rips across the Alabama Hills. Red rock. Real dust. A real cave mouth, dressed with real Stark Industries crates. No green screen anywhere.

A 90-pound suit of hammered, bolted steel, the MARK I, stands on a stand. It's practical, it weighs what it looks like it weighs, and it is ugly on purpose.

JON FAVREAU (40), director, baseball cap, walkie on his hip, circles it like it's a car he's thinking about buying.

ROBERT DOWNEY JR. (41) walks up in a torn, bloodstained tank top, drinking a green smoothie. He knocks on the chest plate. It CLANGS.

DOWNEY  
That's real.

FAVREAU  
That's real.

DOWNEY  
I'm going to be inside that.

FAVREAU  
You said no stunt double. I wrote it down. I had it notarized.

DOWNEY  
(grinning)  
I say a lot of things at 6 AM.

He runs his hand along a weld seam, then gets serious.

DOWNEY (CONT'D)  
Tony built this in a cave. With scraps. With a box of scraps. If it looks like a stunt guy is in there, the whole movie's a lie.

FAVREAU  
So you're in.

DOWNEY  
I've been out for ten years, Jon. I'm in.

A STUNT COORDINATOR hustles over with a harness rig.

STUNT COORDINATOR  
We rigged it for his weight plus ninety. Two guys on safety lines. If he goes down, he goes down slow.

DOWNEY  
Story of my career.

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## SCENE 2

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS – 9242 BEVERLY BLVD – SECOND FLOOR – DAY  
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 – 10:15 AM PT

Downstairs, through the floor, a Mercedes salesman is closing a deal. Up here: cramped offices, a coffee maker from 1994, long boxes of comics stacked against every wall.

KEVIN FEIGE (33), Angels cap, bottle of Diet Coke, stands in front of a WHITEBOARD taped over with butcher paper.

DAVID MAISEL (mid-40s, suit, no tie) closes the door and locks it.

MAISEL

Congratulations, Mr. President  
of Production.

FEIGE

Variety spelled my name right.  
That's a first.

MAISEL

Show me.

Feige tears the paper down.

Underneath: TEN CHARACTER NAMES, the Merrill Lynch collateral, plus IRON MAN, HULK and THOR in red marker. Arrows everywhere. All of them lead to one word circled three times in the middle:

AVENGERS

FEIGE

Eight films. Four and a half  
years. Every one of them stands  
on its own. You could walk into  
any of them cold and you'd love  
it.

(beat)

And every one of them is a  
chapter.

MAISEL

The bank thinks we're making one  
movie about a guy in a tin can.

FEIGE

The bank is right. For now.

MAISEL

Ike is going to ask what this costs.

FEIGE

It costs nothing extra. That's the trick. We're making these movies anyway. We just make them in the same world. Same S.H.I.E.L.D., same scientists, same timeline. Tony's Arc reactor exists in the Hulk movie. Nobody has to notice. Until they do.

Maisel steps closer. He sees something in the lower-right corner of the board, a small sketch in purple marker:

A GAUNTLET. SIX EMPTY SLOTS.

MAISEL

What's that?

FEIGE

That's 2019.

MAISEL

(laughs)

Kevin. We might not exist in 2009.

FEIGE

Then it won't matter. But if we do...

(taps the glove)

Starlin. The Infinity Gauntlet. Thanos wipes out half the universe to impress Death because he's in love with her. We do it exactly like the comic. No watered-down version. No "he wants to save resources." He's a nihilist in love with a goddess.

MAISEL

You're going to pitch Paramount a love story between a purple alien and the Grim Reaper.

FEIGE

I'm not pitching anybody anything.  
(beat)

That's rule one. Nobody outside this room says "universe." Not to agents, not to the trades, not to the actors. The contracts say "sequel options." The audience finds this on their own.

MAISEL

And if they don't?

FEIGE

They will. Fans always do. The first time Nick Fury walks into Tony Stark's living room, some kid on a message board is going to lose his mind. And then he's going to tell a million people.

MAISEL

What's the project called?  
Internally.

Feige looks at the long boxes along the wall. Decades of Stan's Soapbox columns.

FEIGE

Bullpen.

MAISEL

Project Bullpen.

FEIGE

Stan would like it.

Maisel heads for the door, then stops.

MAISEL

One more thing. Avi.

FEIGE

(quiet)

I know.

MAISEL

He built this place.

FEIGE

And he's going to leave it in good hands. I'll make sure of that.

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## SCENE 3

INT. FAVREAU'S PRODUCTION TRAILER — LONE PINE — NIGHT  
MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 — 8:40 PM PT

Favreau has storyboards spread across a folding table and is eating cold craft-services pasta. His flip phone BUZZES.  
CALLER ID: "KEVIN F."

FAVREAU

Day one's in the can. Nobody died.  
Downey was in the suit for eleven  
takes.

FEIGE (V.O.)

(over phone)

Eleven?

FAVREAU

He refused to come out. Said Tony  
wouldn't come out.

FEIGE (V.O.)

That's why we hired him.

(beat)

Jon, I need an extra page.

FAVREAU

We're locked. Paramount's got the  
script, the insurers have the  
script...

FEIGE (V.O.)

It's not in the script. It goes  
after the credits.

Favreau puts his fork down.

FAVREAU

After the credits. Nobody stays  
for that. The ushers are sweeping  
popcorn.

FEIGE (V.O.)

They'll stay for this one.  
Samuel L. Jackson. Eye patch.  
Tony's living room.

FAVREAU

(slow)  
Nick Fury.

FEIGE (V.O.)  
Bryan Hitch drew him as Sam  
Jackson in The Ultimates back in  
2002. Sam knows. He's been  
waiting five years for this call.

FAVREAU  
And he says what?

FEIGE (V.O.)  
"I'm here to talk to you about  
the Avengers Initiative."

A long silence. Favreau looks at the storyboard of the Mark I  
he spent all day shooting.

FAVREAU  
Kevin. What are we making?

FEIGE (V.O.)  
A great Iron Man movie. That's  
all it has to be.  
(beat)  
Skeleton crew. Fake slate. We'll  
call it...  
(beat)  
"Rhodey's Birthday Party." Nobody  
looks twice at that.

FAVREAU  
(laughing)  
Terrence's birthday was  
yesterday.

FEIGE (V.O.)  
Then it's authentic.

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## SCENE 4

INT. STAN LEE'S OFFICE — POW! ENTERTAINMENT — BEVERLY HILLS  
WEDNESDAY, MARCH 21, 2007 — 2:00 PM PT

STAN LEE (84), in tinted glasses, is signing a stack of  
posters with a black Sharpie. FEIGE sits across from him  
holding a single envelope.

STAN  
Kevin! The man in the hat! What  
brings the President of  
Production to see an old  
huckster?

FEIGE  
Your cameo. Iron Man.

STAN  
Tell me I'm Hugh Hefner. I've  
been practicing.

FEIGE  
(smiles)  
Close.  
(slides the envelope over)  
And one more thing. Just for you.  
Read it and give it back.

Stan opens it. One page. He reads it. His Sharpie stops moving.

STAN  
(softly)  
All of them.

FEIGE  
All of them.

STAN  
Same world. Like the comics. Like  
1963. The Fantastic Four in the  
Baxter Building and Spidey  
swinging past the window and the  
Hulk on the news...

FEIGE  
We don't have the Fantastic Four.  
Or Spider-Man. Yet.

STAN  
(grinning)  
"Yet." I like this guy.  
(hands the page back)  
You know what we called it in the  
'60s? The Marvel Universe. The  
fans named it. We didn't. The  
kids wrote letters: "Hey Stan, is  
this the same New York where  
Daredevil lives?" And we said,  
"True Believer... it always was."

FEIGE  
That's the plan. They name it.  
Not us.

STAN  
Excelsior, kid.

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## HEADLINES: SPRING 2007

**VARIETY** | *Thursday, April 12, 2007*

**NORTON'S 'HULK' SETS TORONTO SUMMER START; UNIVERSAL DISTRIBS**

*Leterrier helms. Marvel stresses the pic is "not a sequel" to Ang Lee's 2003 film.*

**AIN'T IT COOL NEWS** | *April 30, 2007*

**Moriarty here with a WHISPER from the Iron Man set...**

*A little birdie says a "mystery day" is on the call sheet with a crew of about 12 people and a code name about a birthday party. Marvel won't comment. Somebody's cooking something, squirts.*

**THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER** | *Thursday, May 31, 2007*

**ARAD EXITS MARVEL STUDIOS**

*Founder steps down to produce independently. Chairman Maisel and production chief Feige to steer the studio's slate.*

**COMICBOOKRESOURCES.COM** | *May 31, 2007*

**THE END OF AN ERA: What Arad's departure means for Marvel's movies**

*"Feige is the guy who knows the difference between Earth-616 and Earth-1610," said one source. "Fans should be very, very happy."*

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## SCENE 5 (CLOSING)

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS — FEIGE'S OFFICE — NIGHT  
THURSDAY, MAY 31, 2007 — 11:52 PM PT

The building is empty. The Mercedes showroom below is dark.

FEIGE (33) is alone. AVI ARAD's farewell card is propped on the desk: "Don't screw up my toys. — Avi."

Feige unlocks a bottom drawer and takes out a three-ring binder. Hand-lettered on the spine:

## THE CODEX

He opens it. The first tab: IRON MAN – MAY 2, 2008.  
Last tab, still blank except for a date:

MAY 2019

He picks up a purple marker and writes one line on the blank page:

"He courts Death. She never answers. That's the whole saga."

He closes the binder. Locks the drawer. Turns off the light.

In the dark, the whiteboard still shows the purple gauntlet sketch. Six empty slots.

CUT TO BLACK.

SUPER: "11 MONTHS UNTIL  
IRON MAN OPENS."

(beat)

SUPER: "12 YEARS UNTIL HE SNAPS."

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**END OF CHAPTER ONE**